Duck, Duck, Goose

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Mr. Albright only called when we weren’t busy.

That was his rule, not ours. If I picked up and said, “Reference desk, this is Valeria,” and there was a line of students behind me, he could hear it somehow. “You’ve got people,” he’d say. “I’ll call back.” And he would, an hour later, when the line was gone.

He was eighty-something. He lived alone and didn’t own a television, only a radio he kept on all day, and whenever he heard a phrase he didn’t understand, he wrote it on the back of an envelope and called the library. Influencer. Gluten free. Ghosting. He’d ask me to find the Wikipedia page and read it to him, slowly, the whole thing, and he’d stop me every few lines to ask a question.

The day he asked about Duck, Duck, Goose, I laughed before I could stop myself.

“I don’t need Wikipedia for that one,” I told him. “It’s a kids’ game. Everybody sits in a circle. One person walks around tapping heads. Duck, duck, duck. Then they tap someone and say goose, and the goose has to chase them around the circle before they steal the goose’s seat.”

There was a pause, and then he laughed so hard he started coughing. “That’s it?” he said. “That’s the whole thing? I thought it was something on the stock market.”

I told him it was close enough.

I thought about him a lot the week the hurricane came.

It wasn’t the worst storm I’d lived through, but it took out the power across all of South Florida, the whole map gone dark. The library closed. My apartment building went quiet in that heavy way buildings do when the air conditioners stop. By the second day nobody could stand to be inside, and we all ended up in the parking lot on coolers and lawn chairs, sharing whatever was going to spoil first.

I had lived there three years and knew maybe four names. By the end of the week I knew everyone. The man in 2B who grilled every piece of meat in his freezer and walked plates door to door. The sisters on the third floor who had a battery radio and

gave hourly updates like news anchors. The Hassan family, who had just moved in, who carried out a case of water bottles and wouldn't let anyone pay them back.

A large tree had come down across the only road out. Its roots stuck up out of the ground like a hand that had lost its grip. On the third morning, everyone who owned a saw, and several people who only owned opinions, gathered to cut it apart so the cars could get through.

Mr. Hassan and his two sons worked harder than anyone. It was Ramadan. They weren't eating or drinking until sunset, and it was ninety-one degrees by ten in the morning. Somebody's grandmother noticed first. She walked straight into the branches, put her hand flat on Mr. Hassan's chest, and said, "No. Sit." He tried to argue. Then the man from 2B took the saw out of his hands, the sisters carried over two lawn chairs, and that was the end of the discussion. The Hassans sat in the shade and supervised. We cut the tree for them. When the sun went down, we all ate together.

That night, by candlelight, I took out my cards.

The funny thing is that my father showed them to me first. My very Catholic father, who has never missed Christmas Mass in his life, kept a deck in a drawer at his apartment, and on the weekends I stayed with him I'd spread the cards on the rug and stare at the pictures. I didn't read them for real until I was grown, when my mother finally told me about Abuela Pepa, the little old woman I saw every Sunday at my grandmother's family BBQ. To me she was the woman who called me her Pololita, but back in their home country everyone in the neighborhood called her La Bruja. People lined up at her door to have their cards read, and afterward she'd have to lie down for an hour. It cost her something, my mother said. She gave it anyway.

I shuffled and thought about Mr. Albright in his apartment with no power and no radio and no one walking a plate of grilled chicken to his door. I pulled one card.

The Six of Cups. Two children in a garden, one handing the other a cup full of flowers. Nostalgia. Simple kindness. The things we learned when we were small and forgot we knew.

I sat with it for a long time.

The power came back on the sixth day. The library reopened on the eighth. I got to the desk early and sat by the phone, not quite admitting I was waiting.

It rang at ten-fifteen.

“Are you busy?” he said.

“No,” I told him. “Not even a little.”

He was all right. A nephew he hadn’t seen in years had driven up from Homestead to check on him and brought batteries for the radio. He sounded pleased about it and a little embarrassed, like someone who’d been handed a present he didn’t think he deserved.

“I heard something during the storm,” he said. “Mutual aid. Can you look that up for me?”

I pulled up the page and started to read. The definition, the history, the whole thing. Then I stopped.

“Actually,” I said, “can I just tell you about my parking lot?”

So I told him. The freezer full of meat. The water nobody would take money for. The fallen tree. The grandmother with her hand on Mr. Hassan’s chest. The way a whole building sat down in the dark and decided to be a family for a week.

He was quiet when I finished.

“So that’s what it means,” he said.

“That’s what it means.”

He thanked me. He said he’d call back tomorrow, and he did, and he asked about a word I don’t remember now. What I remember is the sound of his radio in the background, playing something old, and how I didn’t rush him, and how, for a few minutes, neither of us was alone.

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